

I Bleed, Therefore I Am

The crowd didn't have much of a reaction as Liv made the walk to the cage. A smattering of cheers and some polite applause, but that was all. Steph and Tiz trailed a step or two behind, with Marcy and her bag of tricks bringing up the rear.

Ms. Holt didn't seem too disturbed by the lack of attention from the fans. She danced and stretched a bit. Working off the nervous energy every fighter feels. But she did not look worried or overwhelmed.

The audience perked up a little as Walcott made her entrance. Six straight wins will certainly help your visibility, and Jennifer had a vocal and growing group of fans behind her. Still, the response was muted overall.

No one expected this to take long. No point in getting all worked up over it.

The fighters took their positions and received some last minute strategy from their respective teams. As Jules had done with Dove, Tiz deferred all attention to Steph, who had her usual even demeanor about her.

The seconds cleared out as referee Nell McAndrew motioned the fighters to the center of the cage for their instructions. As with Dove's fight, neither fighter showed any interest in making a production out of the staredown. They just wanted to get the show on the road.

McAndrew sent the fighters to their corners, then motioned for the bell.

The sound was still echoing through the arena as Jennifer flew out of her corner, and I winced as the two fighters came together. It's not that I doubted Steph's assessment. After Dove's performance, how could I? But let's be serious... Liv is mostly untested, and the tests she has faced, she's failed. Walcott knew this, and it was clear she had no intention of playing games. Just go on the attack and see if the blonde can take it because everything she'd shown so far said she can't.

The first point in Liv's favor came when she stood her ground. She knew what Walcott was capable of, but she showed no sign of being intimidated. She simply put her gloves up and faced the assault head on.

Jab. Cross. Hook.

Liv handled it all like a veteran, catching the jab on her guard, slipping the cross and crouching under the hook. She finished by sticking a solid right hand into Walcott's body.

I have no doubt the counter caught Jennifer by surprise, but the brunette model was nothing if not committed. She collected herself quickly and waded back in with another combo.

Jab. Jab. Cross.

Liv was perfect. She fought the urge to jump the gun and kept her guard in place to defend both jabs. Then she saw Walcott shift for the cross and slipped her head right. The brunette's glove sailed by her ear and out came Liv's right again as she popped it into Walcott's face this time.

The crowd was mostly quiet. The early exchanges had been minor, but the wrong fighter had come out on top both times. They were confused.

Walcott stepped back and regrouped, and you could see the little smirk on her face. Liv had stood up pretty well so far, and her fundamentals were better than expected. But there were plenty more weapons in the arsenal. Time to try something more advanced.

The two came together again near the center of the cage and exchanged jabs to no avail. Both backed out, reset and came forward again. Same sort of exchange. Same harmless result. But the next skirmish brought something very different.

Walcott fired a quick jab and took a big step across her own body, leading with her left leg. She planted her foot firmly outside of Liv's own left just as an alarm sounded in my head.

Backfist!

Walcott's move was smooth, sudden and *holy shit*-type fast. The foot came down, her hips rotated and the torsion spun her body like a coil coming unwound. Her right hand tucked up under her chin then shot out like a jackknife and whipped through the space where Liv's head had been.

Had been. Because it wasn't, anymore.

Showing tremendous awareness and a healthy dose of speed of her own, Holt recognized what was happening and had calmly ducked her head out of the danger zone. Jennifer's momentum quickly carried her out of range before Liv could counter.

Unfazed by the miss, Walcott came right back - firing a knee as she reached out to grapple. Knee up, elbow down... Liv closed the gap and defended the knee perfectly, but the effort left her unable to avoid Jennifer's grasp. Once Walcott got her hooks in, she jammed the blonde up against the fence. Liv pushed and ground for position, but Jennifer knew she had her and wasted no time in getting to work.

She pulled her right free and drilled it straight into Liv's face. Holt instinctively reached to tie the hand up again and Walcott unloaded with her left. Then the right came again. Heavy, brutal shots. Liv needed to get out of there.

The blonde gave up on securing her tormentor's hands and went after the body, locking her hands behind Walcott's neck and pulling her close. No good. Closing the distance took some of Jennifer's power away, but the punches kept coming.

This was getting ugly, fast.

Then, just as I started to worry the end was near, Liv planted both hands in Walcott's chest and gave a furious shove. Jennifer was forced back just a small step, but it was all the space Liv needed to circle off the fence. Jennifer turned to chase, and Liv hit her with the one-two.

Bap! Bap!

Walcott's head jerked left then right as the punches hit home. She got her guard up. Liv circled and fired another combo. Jennifer ducked under and countered with a blistering right hand. Liv took the shot but stood her ground. Another combo. Walcott defended and hit her again with the right.

Get out of there, Liv!

She stayed and the two circled. Looking for openings as they fenced with their jabs. Walcott got a little sloppy, and now it was Liv who scored with a right hand. Walcott responded with a hook to the body that landed with a wet smack that told me she'd landed a solid shot to Olivia's ribs. The blonde fought through the blow and shot her jab into the hole in her opponent's guard. A solid hit. Walcott scrambled to gather her defense, but Liv snuck the right through for another score. Walcott answered with her own right but Liv slipped it and hit her with a left hook.

This was nothing like what I'd expected. I had been worried at the start, but Liv surprised me by surviving the early onslaught. Walcott came back with a fearsome clinch game and beaten my fighter like a heavy bag, but Liv had battled her way out of it. Now, the two were trading punches like seasoned heavyweights. The crowd was back into it. This wasn't the fight they'd expected either but it was damned entertaining, and they were letting the women know it.

All of this had happened in just over two minutes.

Walcott tried to clinch again. Liv backed her off with the jab and circled away. Walcott closed again.

Jab. Cross. Right hook.

A brilliant move. Liv had gotten used to the left-right-left rhythm, and Jennifer threw her off by finishing with the two rights. Holt blocked the jab, slipped the cross and took the full force of the hook right on the meat of her cheek. She staggered and Jennifer locked her up in the clinch and slammed her up against the fence.

Not THIS again.

For a few seconds, it was an exact repeat performance. Jennifer pounded Liv with a huge right hand, followed by an equally heavy left. Then Liv skipped straight to what had worked earlier - jamming her palms against Walcott's torso and shoving her away. Only Jennifer had expected it, and she immediately bullied her way forward, hell-bent on keeping Liv against the mesh.

BOOM!

Walcott walked right into a beautifully-timed uppercut that exploded under her chin. The brunette staggered a few steps - just enough to get me thinking she might be going down - before she got her legs back under her and circled away to assess the damage.

Then, as Jennifer worked to gather herself, I saw her absently touch the back of her glove to her chin, then glanced down to observe. I was too far away to see details, but I'd seen the gesture far too many times not to know what it meant. I checked the broadcast to confirm my suspicions.

The force of Liv's punch had torn the skin on the point of Walcott's chin, and a little trickle of blood was now dripping from her face.

Being bloodied in a fight generally garners one of two reactions. The first is that the wounded fighter will wilt a bit. This is common for an inexperienced amateur. The injury reminds her of exactly what she's gotten herself into, and she can no longer deny the risk she's taken. She starts to worry, which only makes her situation worse.

But Jennifer Walcott was no amateur, and she had the other response. The sight of her own blood enraged her. Her blood boiled with the knowledge that she had let this happen to herself, and she immediately vowed to extract revenge from her opponent.

I can easily describe the minute details of this reaction because I am intimately familiar with it. And if Walcott was anything like I thought she was, Liv was about to face a withering assault.

She did not have to wait long.

On the next exchange, Walcott came on like a woman possessed. Jabs. Crosses. Hooks. Punches rained from every angle, but there was nothing frenzied about it. Her mechanics were perfect, her form was meticulous, and her attacks were precise. Above all else, she was simply relentless. Liv stood her ground for a while, even offering a few counters to slow the attack. But when she missed wide with the cross, Walcott had the opportunity she needed. She popped her younger opponent with a fast jab. Liv immediately drew her guard back to protect her head and Walcott slammed a right hook into her body. Liv winced as she retreated but Walcott kept throwing, stepping into a looping left hand. Liv saw it and got her guard up and her head tucked inside. Which lined her up perfectly for the uppercut she never saw coming.

The force of the blast immediately sent the blonde fighter reeling, her torso leading her legs as she backpedaled madly. Walcott gave chase, but, just as the brunette swung, Liv dropped over to her right.

Walcott pulled her punch and quickly followed her wounded opponent to the ground. Hand cocked like a hammer. Ready to pound on Liv until the ref stepped in.

It looked certain that it was over. Liv had fought gamely and she had certainly proven there was more to her than what she'd shown previously. But the end result was still going to be another tick in the loss column.

Then the blonde's hand shot to the canvas and stopped her fall.

Already set in full attack mode, the development barely registered for Jennifer. She just kept coming. Not even noticing the way Liv drew her left leg back. Like an archer pulling a bowstring to full draw. She let it loose, and her foot flew straight and true... right into the center of Jennifer Walcott's face.

The only thing that saved Walcott was how quickly she'd closed on her fallen rival. Liv's kick didn't have far to go, which made the contact more of a push than an impact. Still, it sent the brunette stumbling halfway across the cage. By the time she righted herself, young Ms. Holt was back on her feet.

Jennifer tried hard to hide the question running through her head, but, for just a split second, it was right there on her face for all the world to see.

What the hell just happened?

She looked over at Liv, whose expression also had plenty to say. The blonde's hair was partly undone, and the thin red line winding away from the corner of her mouth announced that the two were now even in the blood-drawing department. But her guard was up, her eyes were focused and there was a small smile pulling at her lips.

Still here bitch.

Right then and there, I made up my mind to stop doubting these rookies of mine. Nothing I had seen from them in the past meant anything now because these were not the same fighters. Steph was right. Something much more than bonding had been going on with the walls of *Rampage Sports*. Lessons had been learned and skills had been sharpened. Their teammates had obviously been very busy teaching them how to win. And it was more than just their skills that had improved. There was something in them now. A hardened steel that hadn't been there before.

Not one to wilt herself, Walcott went back on the attack.

Low kick.

Liv took it on the outside of her leg.

Front kick.

Liv calmly circled her hand in - the second half of the famous *wax on, wax off* maneuver - hooking the brunette's leg and knocking it aside.

Jennifer smartly went with the redirection and stepped clear before Liv could counter. When she turned to square off, Liv hit her with a dismissive shrug.

That all you got?

Hardened steel, these girls.

Walcott came again.

One-two.

Liv read it from the word go, and she was ready. Instead of blocking, she parried the jab - circling her right in and knocking Walcott's arm down. In the same motion, she stepped into her opponent and brought her left hand up high - shielding her head. Jennifer's right bounced off the blonde's guard and slid on by.

One hand knocked down and the other blocked wide. Walcott was momentarily defenseless with Liv right there in her face.

WHAM!

Liv's right shot straight into her opponent's mouth. It was a short but powerful punch - thrown up close and personal - and Jennifer was forced to retreat.

The blonde stayed right with her, stride for stride.

Jab-Cross-Push kick.

Walcott seemed to expect the one-two, but the kick caught her dead in the chest. The result was funny to everyone but Jennifer and her people because it looked like Liv had callously booted her away.

Before she could get her feet set, Jennifer found herself backed up against the cage.

Liv poured it on, pounding her way inside and crushing the brunette against the mesh.

Walcott seemed surprised by the ferocity of the assault. She gave in to the instinct to cover up, and was quickly overwhelmed as Liv swarmed her. Heavy shots were landing and Jennifer couldn't find a lane to fire back. For just a moment, I thought Liv might be able to get the finish right there.

Then Walcott came up with a way to counter, after all. Throwing a deliberate shot to a place where she knew Liv's defense wouldn't be. Not just above the beltline or even at the belt, but well below it.

Liv actually yelled out as the punch hit her nether regions, and she immediately pushed her way clear and put space between them.

Now, I'm not going to get into the anatomical differences between little boys and little girls. That's what health class was for. But, for the record: yes, fellas... it still hurts like hell.

First of all, the area is sensitive, testicles or no.

Second, the impact is just plain shocking. In the course of training, fighters take punches all the time. They become accustomed to it. They know what to expect. And this sure as hell ain't it.

Most importantly, the total lack of defense means a punch like that lands full-force. Liv's job is to guard the areas of her body that are legal targets. It's impossible to do it perfectly and even coming close takes up all of her effort. She can't be worrying about protecting body parts that aren't supposed to get hit in the first place.

The illegal and intentional blow made me furious, but I kept my mouth shut. Danni also said nothing. The punch had been thrown and the damage was done. Yelling about it would make no difference. It was what happened next that would matter. Our anger and outrage meant nothing. Only Liv's response was important.

Lax officiating is a known issue for the league, so I was a little surprised when McAndrew actually saw the foul and jumped in. Not only that, she found the offense so grievous that she skipped the usual step of giving a warning and immediately took a point away from Walcott. While the opposing corner howled in protest, McAndrew gave Liv a moment to recover.

A lucky break? It should have been. Except a rookie is still a rookie, and Liv used the time the wrong way.

She should have gathered herself. Spent the precious seconds recovering from what had been a very active round.

Instead, she was like a kettle heating to boil. You could see it in her eyes and the way the color rose in her face. Like Donald Duck before launching into one of his infamous tantrums. Steam was going to shoot out of her ears any second now.

Experts will tell you temper has no place in the cage. I can tell you different. Used properly, anger is a very powerful tool. It can focus you to a level that is nearly superhuman. But Liv didn't look focused. She looked flat-out pissed. And that wasn't going to help at all.

Though I couldn't hear them, I could see the way Steph and Tiz were shouting into the cage. Both of them banging on the apron as they tried to get Liv's attention, but it was a lost cause.

Oh, Liv... no...

McAndrew motioned for the fight to resume, and it was like someone had waived a matador's cape in front of Liv's face. She charged directly across the cage, hell bent on revenge.

One-two.

Wild, hurried strikes that Walcott easily avoided. She also immediately recognized that Liv was out of control and put it to work for her.

Jennifer waded back in and deliberately put her head in Liv's kill zone. Like putting a ball on a tee.

Liv took the bait and unleashed a bone-breaking right just as Jennifer pulled her head out. The punch missed by a country mile and Liv was left wide-open for the counter uppercut that rattled her teeth and jolted her brain. The blonde staggered a few steps, and, even when she got her feet under her, she still looked dazed.

Walcott circled her clearly wounded prey like a shark. Liv knew she was in trouble and decided to attack. Taking the approach that the best defense was a good offense. Not a bad idea, except her offense wasn't good. It was slow and sloppy and unsteady... and so very easy to counter. Walcott bobbed and weaved - popping a glove into the blonde's face after every miss. Liv just came more and more unglued - swinging bigger and harder, which only opened her defense up wider. The sequence ended with Jennifer popping her jab, then pounding Liv with a left hook-right hook combo. The way that combo flows, the ending right comes straight in, and Walcott's fist landed nearly dead center between the blonde's pretty hazel eyes.

Liv wobbled again before she got her feet under her and circled away.

Then those eyes disappeared, along with the rest of her face, as they were swallowed in a mask of red.

Walcott's overhand right had opened a nasty gash on Olivia's forehead. Damage-wise, it was not nearly as bad as it seemed. Which is good because, to be honest, it looked fatal and it bled like crazy. Something about the blood vessels in that area being close to surface of the skin. I don't know. I'm not a doctor. I don't really understand the medical part. What I am is a fighter. And from that perspective, forehead cuts suck.

First of all, I don't care how tough you are. Bleeding like that is unsettling. You don't even know what's happening at first. No doubt you just got rocked, and you're fighting hard to keep your shit together. Then something's running into your eyes. You think it's sweat, so you try to swipe it away. Then... *what's that stuff on my arm? Oh, it's blood. My blood. And there's a lot of it. And I don't think it's supposed to be out here.*

Pushing the initial shock aside, then come the tactical issues. Or, more accurately, just one issue: you can't see a damn thing. Kind of a big problem. One that compounds itself pretty quickly.

With forty seconds left in the round, Liv wasn't going to be able to just turtle up and survive. She was in deep shit.

And Walcott knew it.

The brunette fighter surged forward, planted her left leg, then whipped her right foot around. No playing games. She was going for it all with one big kick.

Liv somehow saw it, got an arm up to block, then circled away.

Time ticked by. Thirty seconds to go.

Walcott came again.

One-two.

Liv stayed inside her guard. No damage done.

Middle kick.

Liv blocked and circled away.

How the hell was she doing that?

Twenty seconds left.

I took a harder look at Liv, and realized she wasn't panicked. No sign of distraction. She had to keep shaking her head and wiping the blood away, but her eyes stayed locked on Walcott. Every muscle in her body seemed tensed. Ready for anything.

I can use my rage to center me. Apparently, the sight of her own blood focuses Liv in the same way.

Either that, or she was just determined to survive this. To get a chance to make up for her mistake.

With fifteen seconds left, Walcott went for broke. Pushing forward with a relentless series of strikes. Trying to drive Liv to the mesh.

Liv blocked and wove as she retreated, then picked a spot to fire her jab and circle away.

Ten seconds. She was going to survive.

More than that, in fact.

Walcott turned to give one last chase, only to spin directly into Liv's cross. Impact and shock combined to throw the brunette completely out of shape, and Liv just started swinging. Half of her punches missed, and Walcott managed to protect herself from many of the others. But the ones that got through hit like wrecking balls. And there's was no chance for Jennifer to counter because Liv was relentless.

The bell sounded and McAndrew quickly jumped in to separate them.

Walcott came up with an expression that asked, *What the fuck was that?*

Liv just stood and stared at her.

McAndrew instructed the fighters to return to their corners.

Liv just stood there.

Walcott looked confused. Like she didn't know what to do.

Liv just stood there.

Jennifer finally shook her head and stepped around her blonde adversary.

Liv watched her go, moving nothing but her head.

Walcott might have tried to ignore it, but, to everyone else, Liv's message was clear.

Still... fucking... here... BITCH.

Her point made, Liv turned to go to her own corner. That's when I got my first good look at her. Blood was pouring down her face. Running, rather than dripping, from her chin to her chest. Her arms didn't so much hang, as they curved down her sides. Like Superman when some idiot was shooting at him. Bulletproof. The pose made her look twice as big as she really was. Her pace was steady and measured. Her entire torso seemed to rise and fall with her breathing, and the look on her face said the whole world could kiss her fucking ass.

No doubt about it. Our little Liv had gone savage.

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I did a quick assessment as the seconds streamed into the cage. By my estimate, the first round was just about even. Maybe a slight lean to Walcott, but probably not enough to give her the round. Subtract out the lost point for the low blow, and I had Liv ahead 10-9. Worst case, they had split the round 9-9. Pretty good, considering how I felt about things before the night began.

First into the cage for the RSI team was Tiz, with Marcy right behind. Ashley got the stool down, and Marcy practically shoved Liv onto it. She pressed the blonde's forehead back, forcing her patient to look up into the lights as she did a quick assessment. Then she grabbed her kit and went to work.

Everyone - including Liv - seemed to get the message. Time was short, the situation was serious and Marcy was in command.

Steph chose a spot well clear of the fray. I couldn't hear what she said, but I didn't need to. Posture and gesticulations said it all.

Steph calmly held out an upturned palm as she spoke. Liv responded by trying to lift her head, only to have Marcy slap a hand under her chin and force her back again. Liv kept talking, waving her hand dismissively as she did so.

The translation was easy.

Steph: Flipping out like that was stupid, Liv.

Liv: I know, I'm...

SMACK!

Marcy: Sit still or I'll make you sit still.

Liv (to Steph): You don't have to tell me I fucked up. I already know. Let's move on.

And that's exactly what they did. After that, the conversation seemed smooth and matter-of-fact. Both fighter and coach showing proper awareness of the situation. The first round was over, and this was not the time for dissecting whatever mistakes were made. Everything they did and said now needed to be dedicated to getting ready for the round to come.

"What do you think?" Danni asked me.

"She was holding her own pretty well, but that cut looked nasty."

"Marcy'll get it," she said confidently.

I nodded. If anyone could, it was Marcy.

"She'll have to protect it," I said.

"Might not be a bad thing," Danni shrugged. "She was doing better when she let Walcott get herself into trouble instead of trying to force things."

Coming from her, the statement held a lot of weight. Though many fighters prefer a defensive, counter-punching style, I didn't know anyone who could do it the way Danni could. It took an infinite amount of patience and a rock steady confidence in your defense. Danni had those things, and, if she liked the way Liv was making the approach work, then Ms. Holt was obviously doing something right.

"You see the way she went into the break?" Danni asked.

"You mean the *Olivia the Barbarian* bit?"

"You think that's a good thing?"

"Depends," I said. "It shows she's motivated, but she has to focus. She can't lose her mind like that again."

A quiet moment passed while she thought that over.

"I think she'll be OK," she said. "I think Walcott's gonna come to her."

I nodded that I understood. There was literally blood in the water, now. It was a good bet that Walcott, like any good predator, was going to move in for the kill. To go after the injury. Maybe open it up again. At the very least, she would try to make Liv worry about it.

I had no doubt Steph was down there relaying those same thoughts to Liv. The question was, could Holt keep her composure, rely on her defense and wait for her opponent to make mistakes? Or would she be just as eager to go on the attack?

On queue, Steph reached out and put her hand on Liv's arm. Making sure that her fighter understood her next point would be the most important takeaway.

It was not hard to guess what came next.

Liv, you HAVE to control yourself.

Liv nodded that she understood.

McAndrew ordered the seconds out. The RSI team immediately started to gather everything up.

Liv stood. The bleeding had stopped. Marcy is a magician.

Steph offered a few more thoughts, then both teams retreated to the other side of the mesh.

I watched Liv as she shook out her arms and waited for the ref's signal.

There is something of a connection between she and I. The result of a relationship that started on rocky terms.

Olivia first joined the league about four years ago. When I saw her name pop-up on an event schedule, I immediately knew there was a problem. For Ms. Holt only recently celebrated her twentieth year on this Earth and the minimum age for entry into this league is eighteen. And twenty minus four is less than that.

How did she get in? Simple. She lied, and no one checked.

How did she get caught? Also simple. I verified my suspicions, and then I turned her in.

I did it because it had to be done. She wasn't ready, and it was showing in the cage. She was going to get hurt.

But that doesn't mean her little stunt didn't leave an impression on me.

When she reapplied for entry, RSI was quick to snap her up. In fact, she was the first of the rookie trio to come onboard, and she was my decision from start to finish. Danni and Steph were aware, but never officially consulted. And I took a few less than noble steps to make sure I got what I wanted.

Point is, I saw something in her. Still do. She took big risks to get in the cage a few years early. She didn't just want to fight. She needed it.

Danni thinks I'm drawn to Liv because I see some part of myself in her. I'm pretty sure that's right. I'm also pretty sure that's why I was so disappointed at the way her RSI tenure started.

But now, here she was, showing strong signs of being the fighter I thought she could be. She had suffered the ups and downs, and now she was ready to make a statement. To do it, she would have to become like me in ways I wasn't sure she could. No, not become. She had to *BE* like me. It had to already be in her.

Fighters deal with emotion in different ways. Some, like Danni and Emma, keep it pretty bottled up. They show flashes now and again, but they mostly keep their eyes on the prize. To them, the fight is a chess match. They may get angry - both with themselves and their opponent - after the fact, but they know they need to keep their head in the cage to be successful.

Liv was clearly not that kind of fighter. She had been beaten, bloodied and cheated. She had a right to be pissed, and it was pretty obvious she wasn't interested in bottling anything. Her emotions were right there, for all to see. But she had already let her temper get her in big trouble. Could she correct that? Could she harness it and put it to work for her?

If she wanted to win this thing, she would have to.

* * *

DING!

The fighters came out for round two, and, once again, Walcott was the early aggressor. The brunette charged out, then tried to get sneaky with a low kick, but Liv checked it. Then came the right hand, but Liv calmly steered it aside.

Jab, hook.

Liv slipped and dodged like she was reading her opponent's mind. The hook missed badly as Holt dipped outside, and Liv snapped the jab then snuck a short uppercut in from underneath. Quick punches that both found the mark, and forced Walcott to retreat and gather herself. Liv patiently kept pace.

Jennifer tried the low kick again. No luck. Liv blocked it with ease and got right back in her stance.

Then Walcott got tired of messing around.

She fired off the one-two, then surged forward looking to grapple.

Liv seemed to sense what was coming. Maybe Walcott was a little lax in selling the initial combo. Maybe Liv really was psychic. Either way, she waited things out like she knew Walcott's plan. The combo fell harmlessly on her guard, then she fired the jab straight into her oncoming opponent and ducked out of Walcott's path.

When Jennifer turned to find her, Liv's right was waiting.

BOOM!

The arena erupted in a roar as Walcott stumbled back. Liv stayed right with her. As soon as Jennifer tried to straighten up, Liv whacked her with a left hook. Walcott's guard slid over to close that hole and Liv's right came around and hit her from the other side.

Walcott careened into the fence under a barrage of punches from her younger opponent. Jennifer covered up, so Liv stuck a right hand to the body. Walcott's guard shifted that way, and Liv's left found it's way through the new hole.

I honestly didn't understand why Jennifer wasn't firing back. Then she planted her right foot against the mesh and I knew.

Walcott sprang off the fence like she'd been shot out of a cannon and thrust her right hand out in front of her like a spear.

Superman punch it's called. The kind of thing that could end a fight in an instant. And it would have, except Liv saw it coming and dodged out of range.

The move was effective in getting Walcott out of danger, but you could see she was disappointed that she didn't get the highlight reel finish.

Meanwhile, the look on Liv's face told me what I needed to know about where her head was at. And it was what I didn't see that made the biggest impact.

After dodging such a furious blow, most fighters would show a little relief. Maybe even some amusement. A *Ha-ha! Missed me!* moment

Liv's expression showed nothing. No joy, no anger, no sense of having dodged a bullet. Just determination and concentration.

It was then that I understood that she wasn't reading minds. She was simply in the zone. Seeing the action with crystal clarity and reacting without having to think about it.

To me, it looked like she was doing it. Channeling her emotions from the first round. Blocking out the distractions and focusing only on what she needed to do to reach her goal.

Could she keep it up? There was no way to tell until she was tested again.

The two came together again near the center of the cage and Walcott continued to be the aggressor.

Jab, cross, low kick.

Liv guarded the punches then surged forward, stepping inside the kick and planting that right fist of hers in Walcott's face again. Jennifer was forced to back off, her frustration becoming evident. She had plans and strategies. A vision in her head of the way she wanted to control this fight. But Liv wasn't playing along. Blocking and dodging and constantly interrupting her opponent's attacks with that right hand.

Walcott decided to get tricky.

As the two met again, she skipped the ordinary combo starters and went straight for the payoff - unloading a left hook to Liv's body. Holt saw it and got her elbow down to defend. Walcott immediately reloaded the left hand and threw another hook aimed to take the blonde's head off. Liv ducked it like it was nothing, stuck a jab in the center of Walcott's body, then stood and stuffed another right into Jennifer's face.

It suddenly struck me that Liv's counter-punching wasn't just a cheap imitation of Danni's style. It WAS Danni's style. A little rough around the edges for sure, but, overall, a damn fine copy of the real thing.

"She's got a lot of confidence in her defensive abilities," I said. "It looks like there are voices in her head telling her what to do."

Danni gave no immediate reaction.

"Maybe one voice a little more than the others," I continued.

She still offered no comment, but I spotted a smile playing at the corners of her mouth.

I guess I knew which veteran Liv was spending most of her training time with.

In the cage, Walcott gathered herself and tried again.

Jab, Hook.

Jennifer's biggest problem right now was that her jab was doing nothing. Liv was routinely knocking it away without concern, which allowed her to stay focused on whatever followed. And as soon as Walcott's right left her chin, Holt responded with a short left hook. Less powerful but faster, Liv's punch got there first - driving into Jennifer's cheek and sending her own punch awry. But Holt wasn't done. She quickly shifted her weight and launched a looping right of her own. Still reeling from the surprising left, Walcott never even saw the second punch coming. The impact spun her head and it was clear it had her seeing stars as she staggered away. Liv chased her to the fence, launching combo after combo as Jennifer tried to cover up. It was no good. Liv kept the pressure on, landing big shots and making it impossible for Walcott to get out from behind her guard. Again, it felt like the end was near. Like any second Liv would land the shot that ended things. Then Walcott shot her right hand out, and Liv yelled and spun away as she brought both hands up to her left eye.

McAndrew didn't appear to see what happened, but Liv's sudden reaction was enough to tell her something had gone very wrong. She stepped in immediately to halt the action, then checked on Liv. Danni and I checked the broadcast feed to confirm what already seemed obvious, and the replay told the story.

Walcott's right surprised Liv a bit, and she was slightly late getting out of the way. While she avoided any serious impact, the brunette's thumb caught her in the eye.

Unlike earlier, this infraction looked completely accidental. To be honest, Liv's non-stop attack made it impossible for Jennifer to line up anything deliberate. She simply shot the hand out in a desperate effort to back her blonde tormentor off. The result wasn't pretty, but the mission was accomplished. It had gotten her out of trouble, with the added bonus of earning her a brief pause to collect herself.

I doubted Liv was going to be so matter-of-fact about it, though. This was the second time she'd had her opponent under pressure and ready to go, only to have something less than legitimate force her to stop.

With two miserable losses, Holt came into this fight as little more than an also-ran. No one outside of RSI had given her much hope against a fighter of Walcott's caliber. She'd done much better than expected in the first round, but was robbed of her one big chance at a finish. Now she had pretty much owned this second round, only to have another possible finish stolen from her.

It didn't take a brain surgeon to figure out what kind of mood she was going to be in when the action resumed.

Once again, the signs were all there. Her previously impassive expression was gone, and her fury was growing in cycles. First, wipe tears from the eye. Next, try to focus, only to have more tears form. Get pissed off. Then start again with the wiping. Each repetition of the sequence seemed to only get her more aggravated. By the time she finally felt ready to continue, she also looked ready to kill.

"Oh, shit," I said aloud.

"She might be OK," Danni said.

But anger management issues were my area of expertise, not Danni's. Liv had held herself in check so far this round, but this was the test I knew she'd have to face. And even from way up here, I could see she was failing miserably.

Again, Steph and Tiz were urgently trying to get her attention. To somehow break into her runaway train of thoughts and calm her down. No luck. You could literally see her plan written on her face. She was going to rush Walcott, force her to the fence and finish the job. Simple as that.

Walcott saw the plan too, and she decided not to comply.

As McAndrew motioned for the fight to resume, Liv charged straight on, throwing a blizzard of punches as soon as she got in range. Jennifer easily side-stepped the assault, then rocked the blonde with a left hook that sailed in like a missile. Holt was driven sideways by the impact, but Walcott chose not to chase after her.

By this point, the crowd was just about losing it's collective mind. Drawn in by yet another turn in a fight they'd expected to be no contest.

Liv got her feet under her and went right back on the attack. Punching hard but also wild. Walcott chose to fight off her back foot, continuously throwing and landing punches as she retreated from the furious blonde's blind charge. Sensing the fence coming, she nailed Liv with a crisp right, then circled out of danger. Liv walked right through the empty space her opponent had vacated, and that opened up an opportunity for Walcott to make a stand and try to pin Holt against the fence. But again, Jennifer decided not to engage. After all, why risk trading punches when it was obvious Liv was willing to eat blow after blow in an effort to right the wrongs she felt she'd suffered?

And that's exactly what the little blonde nutcase was doing. Despite the way Walcott was scoring, Liv was feeling no pain. So what if blood was seeping from the wound on her forehead? Who gives a shit? She was willing to take whatever Jennifer dished out in order to get her hands on that fucking brunette bitch because once she did...

Did I mention I'm acutely familiar with Liv's current mental state?

Problem is, it doesn't work that way. For one thing, Walcott wasn't dumb enough to be beaten by such an obviously flawed strategy. Beyond that... though Liv's fury and adrenaline might be disguising things, the damage was still being done. She was going to feel it eventually. And though Marcy's repair job was still holding for now, it wouldn't last long at this rate. Of course, that would only be a problem if Walcott didn't knock her out first. With just over two minutes left in the round, that seemed an absolute certainty if she kept going this way.

Someone needed to get through to Ms. Holt, right this damn second.

Luckily, I have just such a person on my payroll.

"GOD DAMMIT, LIV! KNOCK IT OFF!!!"

The words boomed out sharp and clear above the din. The voice powerful and resonant. Because Stephanie McMahon knows how to make herself heard when she wants to.

Even if Liv hadn't heard exactly what was said, the explosion itself was enough to pierce through her rage-induced fog. She took a quick, *what the fuck was that?* glance in Steph's direction, then remembered where she was and got back in her stance.

No harm done because Walcott was just as distracted. Her hands held limply in front of her as she gaped at Steph.

Stephanie, meanwhile, had gotten right back to work. Standing steady and unperturbed at the edge of the apron. Like not only was she not responsible for the outburst, but she hadn't even heard it.

As both fighters shook off the interruption and got back to work, there was no question Liv had seen better days. A rivulet of blood ran straight down from her forehead to the tip of her nose. Her face was beat red, both from the exertion of flailing like a lunatic and from the damage Walcott's fists had done. But

underneath it all, something had changed again. She seemed to be back on center. Like Steph had managed to press some magical reset button somewhere.

As a practitioner of the fury-based arts, I can tell you that's exactly how it works. One minute, you're completely out of your mind. Ready to tear the head off of anyone who gets in your way. Then something breaks the spell, and you're left wondering just what the fuck you were doing a moment ago.

For a few seconds, not much happened. Holt was back on her defensive plan, but Walcott was slow to realize that *Loony Liv* was gone and her opponent would no longer be obliviously walking into punches. So the two fighters just circled each other aimlessly for a while before Jennifer decided she needed to press the action.

Jab, cross.

A simple one, two, and a tentative one at that. Liv guarded well and looked to respond, but Walcott was quick to circle out of range.

More circling. Then another weak one, two from Walcott. Same result for both fighters.

The clock read 3:50. Just over a minute left in the round.

The unimaginative cycle happened once more. The crowd grew restless at the lull in the action.

Then I saw Jennifer motion with her hands. Urging Liv forward.

I checked the broadcast. Walcott was openly daring Liv to attack. Trying to goad her. When Liv failed to respond, the brunette became more animated. Talking and making faces.

To no one's surprise, Jennifer had obviously picked up on Liv's biggest weakness, and she was actively trying to piss her off. But, like most, Walcott failed to appreciate the subtleties involved. Liv's temper was clearly a problem, but it was not completely uncontrolled. She was not some wild animal, foaming at the mouth.

The cheap shot in the first certainly made her mad, but it was the fact that it stopped her attack that really pissed her off. Likewise, I'm sure getting poked in the eye didn't make her happy, but, again, it was the halt in the action that really made her furious.

Why were those things different? Because they were beyond her control. Two tremendous opportunities were gone. Moments when she was only seconds away from victory, only to have it snatched away. And she had no choice but to take it.

But Walcott's mouth. That she could do something about.

Walcott pushed forward behind the one, two again. It was a half-hearted effort. Cocky and weak. More of a taunt than an attack.

C'mon bitch! Fight me!

So Liv did.

As soon as Jennifer started the combo, Holt sprang to life. Ducking right, she got outside the cross, and responded with a right of her own. Just from the way it looked, I knew how good it felt for her. Walcott's jab went nowhere, and her cross missed Liv by barely an inch. The brunette tried to recover, but Liv was already planted and throwing. She put her body into it. The punch was long and crisp and powerful. The perfect counter. Rare as hen's teeth and satisfying as bubble wrap. And Walcott was all out of hands, so there was no defense.

Liv's fist hit nearly dead center. Walcott staggered and tried to back away, but Liv stayed right with her. The fence came quickly. Walcott looked to circle, but Liv was having none of it. She reached out and flat out bullied Jennifer into the mesh.

Then the punches rained down again. A furious blitz of shots from every angle. Any hole she saw, Liv put a fist in and she was connecting with most of them. Walcott was in big trouble. Liv's in-cage conniption made it easy to forget that she'd had her opponent on the ropes only seconds before. Now she was getting another chance, and she was determined to make this one stick. Walcott, meanwhile, was flagging. Feeling the cumulative effects of everything Liv had hit her with so far, and withering under this latest assault.

Another glance at the clock. Twenty seconds to go.

Liv was hammering away. Walcott was overwhelmed. McAndrew was watching closely, yelling for Jennifer to defend herself.

Instinct took over and Walcott reached out to tie up Liv's hands. She got hold of the right but it didn't even slow Holt down. She simply folded her arm and drove the point of her elbow into Jennifer's face.

It was a nasty shot, thrown with no small amount of attitude. Like the words *Fuck you, Jen* should have been tattooed on her forearm for Walcott to read before the elbow smashed her.

It was reminiscent of the savage stare she'd given Walcott after the first, and now it was Danni who was seeing similarities.

"Kid fights with quite an edge to her," she said casually. "Kind of reminds me of somebody."

I smiled. Of all the people in the building, she was the one best suited to make the comparison.

"I don't think that's a learned skill," I said.

"Makes it even scarier," she replied.

The blow rocked Walcott. Liv ripped her hand free and kept throwing. McAndrew was poised and ready to jump in.

Twelve seconds to go.

Walcott threw a desperate right hand that had everything on it. Taking her last shot.

Holt saw it and slipped it. The punch missed by a mile, and Liv put at least four heavy shots into the defensive hole it left behind. The final pair were just gravy because the brunette's hands dropped to her sides after the second impact. Jennifer Walcott was out on her feet.

With four seconds left on the clock, McAndrew pushed her way in-between, ordering Liv back as she waved off the fight.

Liv turned and screamed out loud, leaping so high she was practically flying.

It was not a scream of surprise or astonishment because she had not surprised herself. Tonight - for the first time in her fledgling career - she had walked into this cage fully expecting to win.

It was a scream of rage and satisfaction.

Fuck you! it said. Fuck you and you and you! Fuck all of you!

Because, contrary to everyone else's expectations, Oliva Holt had just arrived.

I kept my outward composure. After all, I am a professional. The owner of a highly successful and highly profitable corporate entity. I have a reputation to maintain.

Inside, I was screaming just as loud as Olivia.

Fuck yeah, Liv! I KNEW you had this in you!

The seconds streamed in. It was Tiz who reached our fighter first, and she caught the victor around the waist as she continued her celebration.

Then Steph arrived, said only a few words, and the hoopla stopped instantly. Liv looked back at her fallen opponent, then dutifully fell in line beside her teammates.

The scene got me thinking again about Steph's predictions. She had given Liv the same odds as Dove, yet there appeared to be no secret strategy this time. No insider tips or fail-proof counters. So how had she been so confident about this one?

My guess was that, somewhere along the way, she realized Liv was an animal who would not be denied.

I turned to Danni.

"You're gonna have to fight me for this one."

"Maybe not," she shrugged. "Maybe she can be the best of both of us."

Holy shit.

Look out world. Here comes Olivia Holt.

* * *

Once again, there was no time to get down to the locker room. Daya would be in action in less than half an hour. But I called down with the same instructions, and we heard back from the big winner in short order.

"You're a psychotic loon," I said to her. "You know that, right?"

"I know. I'm sorry. I just..."

"I'm kidding, Liv," I said. "You don't owe me anything. There are lessons to be learned, but that's for later. For now, just remember... you don't have to make any excuses when you win. Got it?"

"Got it," she said happily.

"You were great out there," I said. "I'm proud of you."

"Thanks."

Just a single word, but I could hear the excitement in it. What she'd done tonight was starting to sink in.

"How do you feel?"

I meant physically. As in, *Did Trish fix that hole Walcott put in your head?* But the answer I got was all about emotion.

"I feel GREAT! This is SO much better than before!"

"Yeah, well... winning will do that for you. And not to put too much pressure on you, but I'm going to expect more of that from now on."

"I'm ready," she said definitively.

"I'll bet you are," I said.

Then I remembered Danni was waiting behind me.

"Listen, I'm going to give you to Danni now, but congratulations again," I said. "I'll see you after Daya's fight."

She thanked me again and then I turned to Danni.

"No earplugs required this time," I said as I handed her the receiver.

"Thank god for small favors," she replied.